



NEW ZEALAND · NZPB

Registration for psychologists

*The New Zealand Psychologists Board
route, and the checklist that goes with it.*

Ethicare Resourcing

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ethicareresourcing.com

What's inside

01 Registering with the Psychologists Board

This guide is free, and so is everything in it. Every chapter here is also on the website, where it is kept up to date — so if you are reading this some months after downloading it, check the site for anything that looks time-sensitive. Fees, tax rates and immigration settings change without much notice.

We don't print these. A PDF costs nothing to send and nothing to ship, which felt like the right answer for a company that spends its days moving people around the world.

Registering with the Psychologists Board

For internationally qualified psychologists. The Board assesses every overseas application on its own merits rather than sorting you into a pathway — so the quality of your evidence, above all for your 1,500 supervised hours, decides how it goes. The checklist is built into the page, so nothing you tick goes out of date.



Regulator

New Zealand Psychologists Board — Te Poari Kaimātai Hinengaro o Aotearoa — under the Health Practitioners Competence Assurance Act 2003

Source

The Board's published requirements at psychologistsboard.org.nz. Where this page and the Board differ, the Board is right.

Status

Checked 3 October 2026 against psychologistsboard.org.nz — the overseas-trained registration page and the Decision Guidelines Relating to Part 2 of the HPCA Act (v1.0). Fees are not printed here because the Board revises them.

Fees & timings

Fees deliberately not printed: non-refundable, different for prescribed and non-prescribed countries, and revised. Check the Board's Fees and Levy page before you budget.

AT A GLANCE

An individual assessment, not a pathway

The Board assesses fitness, equivalence and competence case by case and makes its own judgement of your qualifications. Your evidence shapes the outcome.

Start with the free self-assessment

The Board's online Self-Assessment of Eligibility gives you an early read before you spend a cent or gather a document.

1,500 supervised hours, evidenced in detail

Total hours, the dates they run between, what you were doing and who supervised you. The most scrutinised part of the file — gather it first.

Registration where you trained and where you live

Both are expected. If your qualification would not lead to registration where you obtained it, New Zealand is unlikely.

What's inside

Psychology registration is one of the more rigorous allied-health processes, so read this once end to end, then return to each section as you reach it. The checklist at the end remembers what you have ticked, on this device.

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SECTION 01

Understanding the Board

The New Zealand Psychologists Board — Te Poari Kaimātai Hinengaro o Aotearoa — registers and oversees psychologists under the Health Practitioners Competence Assurance Act 2003. Its purpose is to protect the public by making sure everyone practising as a psychologist is qualified, competent and fit to do so.

The title is protected by law

You cannot lawfully call yourself a psychologist, or practise, without registration and a current Annual Practising Certificate. Registration confirms you have met the standard in a given scope; the APC is what permits you to work, and is renewed every year.

An individual assessment, not a checklist

The single most important thing to understand. Unlike regulators that sort applicants into fixed pathways, the Board assesses every overseas application on its own merits — for fitness, equivalence of qualifications and competence — and it does not rely on assessments by the New Zealand Qualifications Authority. It makes its own. The quality and completeness of your evidence directly shapes the outcome.

Qualification and 1,500-hour internship → Registration in a scope → Annual Practising Certificate → Practise in New Zealand

Start with the self-assessment.

Before anything else, complete the Board's free online Self-Assessment of Eligibility for Registration. It gives you an early read on how the Board may view your fitness, the equivalence of your qualifications and your current competence — so you know where you stand before investing time and money.

SECTION 02

The seven scopes of practice

You apply for registration in a specific scope, and you must evidence the qualifications, internship and practical training relevant to it. If you trained and practise as a clinical psychologist, you will generally apply for the Clinical Psychologist scope. Applying for the wrong one is a costly detour.

General

Psychologist

The general scope.

Most international applicants

Clinical Psychologist

The scope most applicants from clinical backgrounds apply for. Requires clinical training and supervised clinical practice.

Specialist scope

Counselling Psychologist

Evidence of counselling-psychology training and supervised practice.

Specialist scope

Educational Psychologist

Evidence of educational-psychology training and supervised practice.

Specialist scope

Neuropsychologist

Evidence of neuropsychology training and supervised practice.

In training

Intern Psychologist

For those completing the supervised internship stage.

In training

Trainee Psychologist

For those in structured employer-based training, such as Corrections or Defence pathways.

The “psychologist where you trained” test.

One principle runs through every scope: the Board asks whether your qualification would lead to registration in the jurisdiction where you obtained it. If you do not meet the registration or licensing requirements where you trained, you are unlikely to be eligible in New Zealand. The Board also expects you to hold registration both where you trained and where you currently live.

SECTION 03

How the Board assesses your qualifications

Because each application is assessed individually, it helps enormously to know exactly what the Board weighs.

1

A minimum six-year course of studies in psychology

Undergraduate and postgraduate together.

2

An accredited training programme

Recognised by the relevant authority where you trained.

3

1,500 hours of supervised practice as part of your qualification

An internship, closely supervised by a qualified psychologist. Section 04 covers this fully.

4

An endpoint evaluation of your internship, or a licensing examination

Formal evidence that your supervised practice was assessed, not just completed.

5

Registration where you trained and where you currently live

As a psychologist, with a government-mandated authority, in good standing.

If your programme was online or low-residency

Ask before you apply. The Board assesses every overseas application individually for equivalence of qualifications, and a programme delivered substantially at a distance is harder to evidence as equivalent to a six-year, accredited, in-person New Zealand training. The Board does not publish a blanket rule on this, so the answer comes from your own eligibility self-assessment and, if needed, a direct question to the Board — not from a page like this one.

What the Board does publish

A minimum six-year course of studies in psychology, from an accredited training programme, with the 1,500-hour supervised practice completed as part of it.

Where to settle it

Start with the Board's online Self-Assessment of Eligibility. It is the first step in the process and it exists precisely to answer questions like this before you pay a non-refundable fee.

Prescribed countries: a note on fees, not a fast track.

Canada, Ireland, South Africa, the United Kingdom and the USA are "prescribed countries". Applications from them tend to be quicker and cheaper to process because their training and regulation closely resemble New Zealand's. It is not a separate pathway and it does not change the standard you must meet. Psychologists registered in Australia use Trans-Tasman mutual recognition instead.

SECTION 04

The 1,500-hour supervised practice requirement

The requirement international psychologists most often stumble on. You must provide conclusive, clear and reliable evidence of a structured, supervised and formally evaluated practice programme of at least 1,500 hours completed as part of your qualification, approved by the Board or an equivalent registering authority. Get this evidence right and you remove the single biggest cause of delay.

1,500

Hours in total

A structured, supervised and formally evaluated practice programme completed as part of your qualification.

Semi-

independent

When the hours start

The Board counts from when you "actually commenced practising (under appropriate supervision but semi-independently) as a psychologist", and stops when the placement contract ends. Earlier practica do not count.

Closely

supervised

By a qualified psychologist

The programme must have been structured, supervised and formally evaluated, and completed as part of your qualification rather than alongside it.

When the hours count from

The Board counts your internship from when you began practising as a psychologist — supervised, but semi-independently — through to the end of your placement contract. Internships normally come toward the end of training and are distinguished from earlier practica by the greater independence you are given. Practicum

hours from early in your training generally do not count toward the 1,500.

Gather this evidence first.

It is the hardest to reconstruct and the most scrutinised. Aim for documentation showing the total hours, the breakdown of activities, the proportion of direct client contact and the supervision arrangements, ideally confirmed by your training institution or supervisor. A letter that simply states “completed an internship” rarely satisfies the Board.

SECTION 05

Eligibility and documents

Alongside your qualifications and internship evidence, the Board needs a set of supporting documents. Each exists for a reason, and understanding why makes it easier to satisfy.

Present it like a professional portfolio: clean, high-resolution colour scans; pages straight and complete; consistent naming; certification done correctly the first time. A well-organised application is read more favourably, and assessed faster, than a disorganised one containing exactly the same facts.

Evidence of qualifications and training

Why

Your degrees and diplomas are the foundation of registration, and the Board makes its own assessment of them rather than relying on NZQA.

Provide

Full detail of the course content of your undergraduate and postgraduate degrees and diplomas, plus everything relating to internships and practical training.

Mistake

Thin course-content detail, especially from outside the UK, South Africa or the USA — the Board needs it to judge equivalence.

Evidence of current registration

Why

The Board needs to confirm you are registered or licensed where you trained and where you live, and in good standing.

Provide

Details of your current registration with a recognised authority, such as a state or national registration body.

Mistake

A qualification that is not eligible for registration as a psychologist where you trained — the application will be declined.

Evidence for each scope

Why

Registration is scope-specific.

Provide

Evidence of the applicable qualifications, internships and practical training for each scope you are applying to register in.

Tip

Confirm your scope first (Section 02), then gather evidence specific to it.

Identity and supporting documents

Why

To confirm who you are and link your records.

Provide

Certified identity documents, evidence of any name change if your name differs across documents, and translations of anything not in English.

Tip

Scan flat, in colour, with all edges visible; confirm who may certify before you pay.

SECTION 06

References and criminal history

Two requirements with precise rules that are easy to get slightly wrong — and a small error means starting that piece again. The Act requires you to be a “fit and proper person”; these are how the Board confirms it.

References

Three rules

Three references, on the Board’s own reference template. At least one should come from a senior psychologist registered, chartered or licensed with a government-mandated registration authority overseas — with a copy of that referee’s own registration certificate or licence.

The original document, signed and dated no earlier than three months before the Board receives your application — or emailed by the referee directly to the Board with your name in the subject line.

Referees should have known you for at least twelve months, ideally professionally. Family members and friends are not suitable.

Criminal history

Four rules

From each country you have lived in for longer than three months within the past five years.

The official source for each country — for example ACRO Police Clearance in the UK, the Australian Federal Police certificate, the South African Police Clearance Certificate, or FBI and state-level checks in the USA.

No more than six months old, including all names you are or were known by.

Requested directly from the police in the country concerned. Third-party pre-employment checks are not accepted.

A conviction is not an automatic bar.

The Board considers each case on its merits. The right approach is full, honest disclosure: submit the record and an explanatory letter. Non-disclosure is treated far more seriously than most underlying matters.

SECTION 07

English language requirements

Safe, precise communication with clients and colleagues. The Board's bar is specific, and higher than in some professions.

You need a test only if both of these are true.

English is not your first language, **and** your psychology qualifications were not completed in English in Australia, Canada, South Africa, the United Kingdom, Ireland or the United States. If either does not apply to you, you generally will not need a test.

7.5

Overall

IELTS Academic is the only English test the Board currently accepts.

7.0

In every section

A strong average does not rescue one component below the line. Prepare evenly across all four.

2 yrs

Validity

Results must have been obtained within two years before you apply.

1

One Skill Retake

The Board accepts IELTS One Skill Retake results, so narrowly missing one component need not mean sitting the whole test again.

Sitting the test too early.

Psychology applications can take several months to assemble, so an early IELTS risks expiring before you submit. Time the test so the result is still valid when your application reaches the Board.

SECTION 08

Cultural competence and the Raka Māui programme

The practice of psychology in New Zealand reflects the world views of both partners to te Tiriti o Waitangi.

The Board's Core Competencies include cultural competencies, and registered psychologists are expected to be culturally competent with all cultures — and particularly to safeguard the wellbeing of Māori, as part of a system-wide effort to address the effects of colonisation on Māori health. You can begin before you relocate, and demonstrating that you have started carries real weight with the Board. You are also welcome to make submissions to the Board about your practice in terms of cultural safety generally.

RAKA MĀUI — A CONDITION OF YOUR REGISTRATION

Not optional, and not a mark against you

This is the part of the process that changed most recently, and it is the one to plan around. The Board's **Raka Māui Competence Programme** applies to eligible overseas-trained psychologists **whose applications for registration are approved by the Board on or after 1 July 2026**. Completing it **is a condition of your registration**, and it must be completed **within two years of registration**.

It is not a judgement on your clinical ability. Because overseas applicants have typically not trained or practised with Māori, its express purpose is to build the cultural capability needed to practise safely in a country where tangata whenua have unique and specific needs. Treat it as part of the job you are taking, with two years to do it in — not as paperwork to be avoided.

Required, once registered

Raka Māui Competence Programme

The Board's own programme, and a condition of registration for anyone approved on or after 1 July 2026. Two years from registration to complete it. The Board publishes the programme guide on its website.

Useful beforehand

Getting a head start

Nothing replaces Raka Māui, but arriving with some grounding helps. The Board also publishes Cultural Safety Guidelines and a Tangata Whenua reading list, and both are worth working through before you land.

SECTION 09

Applying, and what happens next

Once your evidence is assembled, the application itself is methodical.

1

Complete the self-assessment

The Board's online Self-Assessment of Eligibility gives you an early read before you commit time and money.

2

Confirm your scope

Identify which of the seven scopes your training evidences, and gather evidence specific to it.

3

Assemble your evidence

Qualifications and course content, the 1,500-hour internship breakdown, registration evidence, references, criminal-history records, and IELTS results if required.

4

Read the Board's cultural safety material

Groundwork before you arrive. The required programme, Raka Māui, begins after you are registered and runs for up to two years.

5

Submit your application and fee

Overseas applications go to the Board with the application fee, which is non-refundable.

6

Individual assessment

The Board assesses your fitness, equivalence and competence, and sets the conditions your registration will carry.

7

Registration, then your APC

Once registered in your scope, apply for your Annual Practising Certificate before you can practise.

How long it takes — our experience, not a Board figure

Allow ample time

Overseas psychology applications commonly take around four to six months, and longer from outside the prescribed countries because the Board examines course content in more depth. The completeness and clarity of your evidence is the biggest factor within your control.

Fees

Always check the current figures

No amounts are printed here deliberately. Application fees are non-refundable, differ between prescribed and non-prescribed countries, and are reviewed periodically. Confirm them on the Board's Fees and Levy page before you budget or pay.

— WHERE PEOPLE GET STUCK

Almost every avoidable delay traces back to one of these

Weak internship evidence

The biggest one. Letters that do not show the 1,500 hours, the dates, the nature of the work or the supervision arrangements — or that count practica from before you were practising semi-independently.

The in-residence problem

A largely online, weekend or summer-intensive qualification that does not meet the one-continuous-year requirement.

Wrong scope

Applying for a scope your training does not evidence. Confirm your scope first.

Unsuitable referee

No senior overseas-registered referee with their certificate, or references signed more than three months before submission.

Third-party police check

A pre-employment background check instead of one requested directly from the police, or one older than six months.

IELTS too low or too old

Below 7.5 overall or 7.0 in a section, or results expired before submission.

Thin course-content detail

Especially from non-prescribed countries: too little for the Board to judge equivalence.

The fix for all of these

Do the self-assessment, gather internship evidence first, confirm your scope, and have everything reviewed before you submit. Most of these are invisible to the person making them.

SECTION 11

The questions we are asked most

Should I do anything before applying?+

Which scope should I apply for?+

My qualification was partly online. Is that a problem?+

Do my practicum hours count toward the 1,500?+

I am registered in Australia. Does that help?+

Do I have to do the Raka Māui programme?+

Do I need IELTS?+

How long does it take?+

Can Ethicare review my application?+

SECTION 12

The whole journey on one page

From first decision to first day at work. Each stage links to the section that explains it; the checklist tracks the same stages.

Before you start

Complete the self-assessment

The Board's free online eligibility check — before a single document. [Section 01](#)

Before you start

Confirm your scope

Which of the seven scopes your training and supervised practice evidence. [Section 02](#)

Start today

Gather your internship evidence first

Hours, activities, direct client contact, supervision — confirmed by your institution or supervisor. [Section 04](#)

Preparing

Assemble the supporting documents

Course content, registration evidence, references and police records, timed so the three-month and six-month limits hold on the day the Board receives them. IELTS if you need it. [Sections 05–07](#)

Preparing

Read the cultural safety material

Groundwork before you arrive. Raka Māui itself starts after registration. [Section 08](#)

Applying

Submit, then the individual assessment

With the non-refundable fee. The Board assesses fitness, equivalence and competence, and sets the conditions your registration will carry. [Section 09](#)

Decision

Registration in your scope

Confirmed by the Board, with Raka Māui to complete within two years.

Then

Annual Practising Certificate

A separate application — and what lets you practise.

Then

Employment, visa and the move

Where registration hands over to [planning your move](#).

THE CHECKLIST

Thirty-eight items, in the order you will meet them

Tick as you go. Ticks are saved on this device only — nothing is sent to us — and the list is always the current version, which a downloaded copy never is.

0 of 38 ticked

01 Before you start

Get oriented before you spend money or gather documents.

- ☐ **Complete the Board's online Self-Assessment of Eligibility** The essential first step — an early read on fitness, equivalence and competence.
- ☐ **Confirm which of the seven scopes fits your training** Psychologist, Clinical, Counselling, Educational, Neuropsychologist, Intern or Trainee.
- ☐ **Check you hold registration where you trained AND where you live** Both are required. If you cannot register where you trained, New Zealand is unlikely.
- ☐ **Run the Board's Self-Assessment of Eligibility** The first step in the process. Settle any doubt about an online or low-residency programme here, before the non-refundable fee.
- ☐ **Note the current fees** Non-refundable, and they differ between prescribed and non-prescribed countries. Check the Board's live page.

02 Internship evidence — start this first

The 1,500-hour requirement is the most scrutinised part of the application.

- ☐ **Evidence of 1,500 or more supervised practice hours** Structured, supervised and formally evaluated, as part of your qualification.
- ☐ **Show at least 50% in service-related activities** Treatment, assessment, interviews, report writing, case presentations, consultations.
- ☐ **Show what the hours consisted of** Assessment, intervention, report writing, consultation — and how much of it was direct client work.
- ☐ **Show the supervision arrangements** Who supervised you, their registration, how often and in what form.
- ☐ **Confirm the hours count from semi-independent practice onward** Early practica generally do not count toward the 1,500.

03 Qualifications and registration

What the Board assesses for equivalence.

- ☐ **Evidence of a minimum six-year course of studies in psychology**
- ☐ **Full course content, undergraduate and postgraduate** Especially detailed if you trained outside the UK, South Africa or the USA.
- ☐ **Evidence your programme is accredited** Endpoint evaluation or licensing exam evidence.
- ☐ **Proof of current registration or licensure** With a recognised state or national authority, in good standing.
- ☐ **Evidence for each scope you apply under** Qualifications, internships and training specific to that scope.

04 Identity and references

Confirming who you are, and that you are fit and proper.

- ☐ **Certified identity documents** Plus name-change evidence if your name differs across documents.
- ☐ **Certified translations of any non-English documents**
- ☐ **At least one senior overseas-registered referee** Registered, chartered or licensed — include a copy of their registration certificate.
- ☐ **References original, signed and dated within three months** Or emailed by the referee directly to the Board, with your name in the subject line.

☐ **Referees who have known you professionally for 12 months or more** Family and friends are not suitable.

05 Criminal history

Police records with precise rules that are easy to get slightly wrong.

☐ **Police record from each country you have lived in** Any country you lived in for more than three months in the past five years.

☐ **Requested directly from the police** Third-party pre-employment checks are not accepted.

☐ **No more than six months old, with all your names included**

☐ **Explanatory letter if you have any conviction** A conviction is not an automatic bar. Disclose fully and explain.

06 English language, if required

Only if English is not your first language and your qualifications were not in English in Australia, Canada, South Africa, the UK, Ireland or the US.

☐ **Sit IELTS Academic — the only accepted test** Required only if the condition above applies to you.

☐ **Meet 7.5 overall with no section below 7.0** A high bar. Prepare evenly across all four.

☐ **Results obtained within the last two years** Time it so they are still valid at submission.

☐ **Consider IELTS One Skill Retake if you miss one section** The Board accepts One Skill Retake results.

07 Cultural competence — get ahead of it

Raka Māui is a condition of your registration. Groundwork before you relocate makes it easier.

☐ **Review the Board's Cultural Competence information** Te Tiriti o Waitangi and Māori health expectations.

☐ **Start the Foundation Course in Cultural Competency** Free and optional, at learnonline.health.nz.

☐ **Consider the Mauri Ora cultural course** Specifically recommended by the Board.

☐ **Plan for Raka Māui** A condition of registration for anyone approved on or after 1 July 2026, to be completed within two years of registering.

08 Submit, and after

Putting it together, and what follows.

☐ **Assemble everything as a clean, organised application** Clear colour scans, certified where needed, well named.

☐ **Pay the non-refundable application fee** Confirm the current figure for your country first.

☐ **Submit to the Board** Individual assessment of fitness, equivalence and competence follows.

☐ **Respond promptly to any Board queries** Speed of response is the biggest factor within your control.

☐ **Registration confirmed — note the Raka Māui deadline** Two years from registration.

☐ **Apply for your Annual Practising Certificate** Required before you can practise.

Print or save as PDF

— WHAT NEXT?

Registration is one part of the decision

Check my pathway Registration and eligibility only — scope, the in-residence rule and English, before you gather a single document. **How registration works in New Zealand** For every profession — the boards, the sequence, English and timelines. **Mental health in New Zealand** The family of professions, and the pages for

each. **Psychologist**What the work is like, indicative pay under the APEX agreement, where you could live.
Plan your moveRegistration, visas, family and the order to do it in — personalised, saved in your browser.

HOW WE HELP

We can read it before the Board does

We review your evidence — particularly your internship documentation and scope choice — against what the Board looks for, and flag likely issues while they are still easy to fix. We support and guide you through the process; the registration decision always rests with the New Zealand Psychologists Board.

Talk to Ethicare

The Board's own site ↗